In the Attic

Comprehension – Textual Passage
1.Read the excerpt from In the Attic and answer the questions that follow:

We went into the next room where a piano stood by the wall. The officer pointed to the instrument. “Play something!” I looked enquiringly at him and did not move. He obviously sensed my fears, since he added reassuringly, “It’s all right, you can play. If anyone comes, you can hide in the larder and I’ll say it was me trying the instrument out.” When I placed my fingers on the keyboard they shook.

I hadn’t practised for two and half years, my fingers were stiff and covered with a thick layer of dirt, and I had not cut my nails for some weeks. I played Chopin’s Nocturne in C sharp minor. When I finished, the silence seemed gloomy and eerie. I heard a shot down below outside the building – a harsh, loud German noise.

The officer looked at me in silence. After a while he sighed, and muttered, “All the same, you shouldn’t stay here. I’ll take you out of the city, to a village. You’ll be safer there.” I shook my head. “I can’t leave this place,” I said firmly. Only now did he seem to understand my real reason for hiding among the ruins. “You’re Jewish?” he asked. “Yes.” “Yes, well,” he murmured, “in that case I see you really can’t leave. Where are you hiding?” “In the attic.”

Questions
1. Why did the officer encourage the narrator to play the piano?
2. What physical condition was the narrator’s hands in when he played the piano?
3. Why didn’t the officer force the narrator to leave his hiding after realizing he was Jewish?
4.Which of the following show the danger present in the setting?
A. The officer’s reassurance

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B. The narrator hiding in ruins
C. The gunshot heard outside
D. The gloomy silence after the music
i) Only A is correct
ii) A and D only are correct
iii) B,C&D are correct
iv) None of the above
2. Which details reveal the narrator's long period of hiding?
A. He had not practiced piano for two and a half years
B. His fingers were dirty
C. The piano stood by the wall
D. His nails were uncut
i) A,B&D are correct
ii) C is correct
iii) Both C and D
iv) A only
6. Pick out the word that means 'strange and frightening, creating an uncomfortable feeling'?

2. Read the excerpt from In the Attic and answer the questions that follow.

On 14 January unusual noises in the building and the street outside woke me. Soldiers ran up and down the stairs, and I heard agitated, nervous voices. Early in the morning of 15 January, the sound of artillery from the previously silent front was heard. The ground and the walls of the building shook under the constant dull thunder.

Three hours later the heavy artillery fire died down again, but I was as nervous as ever. I did not sleep at all that night. The street fighting would begin at any moment, and I could be killed. The night passed peacefully. Around one o'clock I heard the remaining Germans leaving the building. Silence fell. I could not even hear the steps of the guards outside the building. Not until the early hours of the next day was the silence broken by a loud and resonant noise, the last sound I had expected. Radio loudspeakers set up somewhere nearby were broadcasting announcements in Polish of the defeat of Germany and the liberation of Warsaw.

1. What events occurred during the night of 14–15 January that caused the narrator fear and anxiety?
2. Match Column A with Column B

Column A	Column B
i. Artillery	a. Announcements of liberation
ii. Silence	b. Heavy weapons causing explosions
iii. Radio loudspeakers	c. Germans leaving the building
iv. Street fighting	d. Fear of death

3. Which of the following details show that the narrator was living in danger?
a. Soldiers running up and down the stairs
b. The shaking of walls and ground
c. The music heard from polish radio
d. Fear of being killed in street fighting

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i) a&c
ii) c only
iii) a,b&d
4. Find the word from the passage that means ‘set free from control or occupation’.
5. By the end of the passage, the fear of death and violence turns into surprise and relief. Which sentence from the passage gives you the hints for that?

Answers
SET 1
1. The officer wanted to hear the narrator play and reassured him that he would protect him by claiming he himself was trying the instrument if anyone came.
2. His fingers were shaking, stiff from lack of practice, dirty, and his nails were uncut.
3. The officer understood that being Jewish made it impossible and extremely dangerous for the narrator to leave his hiding place, which led him to respect the narrator’s decision.
4. B,C&D are correct
5. A,B &D are correct
6. Eerie
SET 2
1. Soldiers were running through the building, artillery fire shook the walls and ground, the narrator could not sleep, feared street fighting, and heard German soldiers leaving the building.
2. Match the following
i Artillery → b. Heavy weapons causing explosions
ii. Silence → c. Germans leaving the building
iii Radio loudspeakers → a. Announcements of liberation
iv Street fighting → d. Fear of death
3. a, b&d
4. liberation

DISCOURSES

I. “In the Attic” by Władysław Szpilman powerfully portrays the theme of human endurance and the will to survive amidst the horrors of war and persecution. It's a survival testemony that reflects the never ending resilience of human spirit. Prepare a detailed **Review** of ‘In the Attic’ focusing on its characterization, theme and plot development.

In the Attic is a touching survival story based on the real-life experiences of Władysław Szpilman, a Jewish pianist who struggles to stay alive during World War II. Set against the ruins of war-torn Warsaw, the narrative highlights the strength of the human spirit and the power of hope even in the darkest times.
The central character, Szpilman, is portrayed as a quiet, sensitive, and deeply artistic man. At the beginning, he lives a normal life as a pianist, but war turns hisworld upside down. As he loses his family and freedom, his character develops into one of great courage and endurance. Though physically weak and starving, he never gives up the will to live.

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Another important character is the German soldier who unexpectedly helps Szpilman. Though he belongs to the enemy side, he shows kindness and humanity by giving him food and protecting him. This soldier represents compassion even in cruel times and reminds us that goodness can exist anywhere.

One of the major themes is survival and resilience. Szpilman's struggle shows how humans can survive extreme hardship with hope and determination. Another theme is identity under threat. As a Jewish man and an artist, Szpilman's very existence is in danger, yet he clings to his identity as a pianist.Music as a connection is also a powerful theme. Music becomes a symbol of life and hope. When Szpilman plays the piano for the soldier, it creates a deep emotional bond between them.

The story also reflects compassion and humanity. The soldier's unexpected kindness proves that even during war, people can rise above hatred. Finally, freedom after war is shown when Szpilman survives to see the end of the war and regains his dignity and life. When Nazis invade Poland, Szpilman's life slowly collapses. His family is taken away, and he is left alone to survive in hiding. He takes shelter in ruined buildings and in an attic, living in constant fear of being discovered. Hunger, loneliness, and illness weaken him, but he continues to fight for life.

The turning point comes when he meets the German officer. Instead of arresting him, the soldier shows sympathy and secretly supports him. Szpilman plays the piano for the officer. This moment highlights the power of art and humanity.

The story ends with the war coming to an end. Szpilman survives and returns to his profession as a pianist, symbolizing hope and freedom. In the Attic is a deeply moving story of courage, hope, and kindness. It teaches us that even in times of extreme cruelty, humanity and compassion can still shine. The story reminds readers to value life, freedom, and empathy. Through Szpilman's journey, we learn that hope and resilience can help us overcome even the darkest moments in history

2, The German officer shows empathy towards Szpilman choosing kindness instead of violence and brutality. Prepare the diary entry of the officer on the day of their last meeting before he leaves Warsaw

December 12, 1944
Tonight, silence presses against my ears more cruelly than gunfire ever did. I have just left that broken man behind in the attic — Władysław Szpilman, a Jew, a pianist, and perhaps the last living soul in this ruined city.
I should have reported him. That is what a German officer is trained to do. That is what duty demanded of me. Yet my hands refused to move, my voice refused to betray him.
When he sat at that ruined piano and played, the world I believed in collapsed. In those trembling notes, I heard humanity crying out beneath the boots of war. He was not my enemy. He was a starving artist clinging to life with dignity I no longer recognize in my own uniform.
All my life I was taught that obedience is honour. But today I discovered that obedience can also be cowardice. I gave him food. I gave him a coat. I gave him hope. In doing so, I may have signed my own death warrant. The Red Army is close now. My comrades are desperate. Our cause is crumbling. If they find out what I have done, I will be shot as a traitor.

And yet — for the first time in years — I feel calm and true.
The war has stripped me of illusions, of faith in orders, of pride in my rank. It has turned men into wolves and cities into graves. But tonight, in a shattered building with a half-dead pianist, I reclaimed something the war tried to kill in me — my conscience. I am afraid. Afraid of capture. Afraid of execution. Afraid of what history will call men like me. But more than that, I am afraid of becoming a man who survives by crushing the innocent. If this war ends — and God, I pray it does — I hope Szpilman lives to play again. I hope the world remembers that even in the darkest ruins, a man can still choose mercy over murder.
If I die, let it be known that on this night, I stopped being a soldier of hatred and became, once more, a human being. — Wilm Hosenfeld

3. Szpilman has to prove himself at the gunpoint even in the liberated Warsaw. Construct a conversation between Wladislaw Szpilman and the Polish officer who questions him about his identity on the last day of his hiding.

Officer : Hands up! Don't move!
Szpilman : Please don't shoot! I'm Polish! I'm one of you!
Officer : Polish? Then why are you hiding in this ruined building?
Szpilman : I was in hiding during the war. I thought the Germans were still here. I was afraid to come out.
Officer : Then why on earth are you wearing a German coat?
Szpilman : I had no choice, sir. I found it in an abandoned house. I was freezing and starving.
Officer : What is your name? Answer clearly!
Szpilman : My name is Władysław Szpilman. I am a Polish pianist from Warsaw Radio.
Officer : A pianist? Why didn't you come out earlier when the city was liberated?
Szpilman : I heard gunshots and explosions. I thought the Germans were fighting back. I feared I would be killed.
Officer : You're safe now, Mr. Szpilman. The war is over for you.
Szpilman : Oh! Thank God! At last, we are free.

4.War creates endless struggles and issues to the people of both sides. Moreover the increasing number of people who flee from their country remains as a threat to the global peace. Refugees are forced to face many difficulties in the countries where they seek shelter. Prepare a speech on The Global Refugee Crisis to be delivered in your school assembly.

Good morning to one and all.
Today, I rise not merely to deliver a speech, but to give voice to a silent human tragedy — the tragedy of refugees.
Every year on June 20, the world observes World Refugee Day. But for over 80 million displaced people worldwide, every day is a refugee day. Every sunrise greets them with uncertainty. Every sunset reminds them of what they have lost — their homes, their security, their loved ones, and often, their dignity.
According to the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, nearly 26 million

people today live as refugees outside their countries of origin. These are not numbers on a page. These are mothers who carried their children across borders. These are fathers who stayed back to fight or were lost forever. These are children who have forgotten what a classroom looks like and have learned instead the language of fear. War does not only destroy buildings.It destroys childhoods, futures, and faith in humanity.

Refugees flee because they must — because staying means death, persecution, hunger, or imprisonment. They leave behind graves of their ancestors, the walls that heard their laughter, and the streets that knew their footsteps. They carry their entire lives in a small bag and their memories in a broken heart.

Refugees are forced to live in overcrowded camps, often without adequate food, clean water, shelter, or healthcare. Diseases spread easily. Trauma goes untreated. Children grow up without education, without stability, and without hope. Many of them have never known a world without conflict. They are not running towards luxury.

They are running away from death.

The global response to this crisis has been painfully unequal. While some countries shoulder the responsibility of hosting millions, others turn away, building walls instead of bridges. The distribution of humanitarian aid remains unjust, and political interests often take priority over human lives. This is why the refugee crisis is not only a political issue. It is a moral issue. It is a human issue. Dear friends, imagine this question for a moment: If war came to our city tonight, if bombs fell on our homes, if our schools were reduced to rubble — would we not also become refugees? The only difference between “us” and “them” is geography and fate. Refugees do not ask for charity. They ask for safety. They ask for dignity. They ask for a chance to rebuild their lives.

On this World Refugee Day, let us move beyond sympathy to solidarity. Let us replace indifference with empathy. Let us choose compassion over convenience. Let us work towards a world where no child has to grow up in a refugee camp, where no mother has to choose between hunger and bullets. Thank you. Let humanity guide us all.

PHRASAL VERBS

A) fall on – attack suddenly or be the responsibility of.
Eg: Then his glance fell on the door to the other room.
B) stand by – support someone or be ready to act.
Eg :We went into the next room where a piano stood by the wall.
C) turn on – start a machine or device; also means to excite or suddenly attack.
Eg: Through the paper, I felt several loaves and something soft, which later turned out to be jam wrapped in greaseproof paper.
D) come in – enter a place.
Eg : The guards saw me come in here, and I mustn’t stay long.
The first hard frosts came in the middle of December.
E) hang on – wait or hold tightly.
Eg:” You must hang on, do you hear?”
F) went over – examined or reviewed carefully (past tense of go over).
Eg : In my mind, I went over every Christmas before and during the war.
G) set up – arrange, organize, or establish.

Eg: Radio loudspeakers set up somewhere nearby were broadcasting announcements in Polish of the defeat
of Germany and the liberation of Warsaw.
H) put it on – wear something or pretend.
Eg : I had already put it on when I suddenly heard the rhythmic footsteps of guards out in the road again.
I) sink on – to gradually lean or collapse onto something.
Eg : I sank on my mattress, utterly dejected, and lay there until something new came to my ears:
J) take to one's heels – run away quickly.
Eg : She stared at me, dropped her bundle and took to her heels with a shriek of, "A German!"
K) look out – be careful or watch for danger.
Eg : Looking out of my little window a few minutes later, I saw that the whole building was surrounded.
L) walk through – practice or explain step-by-step.
Eg : After two weeks, well cared for by the military, I walked through the streets of Warsaw without fear, a free man, for the first time in almost six years.
M) look over – examine or check something quickly.
Eg : I looked over to the north of the city, where the ghetto had been, where half a million Jews had been murdered— there was nothing left of it.
N) go on – continue or happen.
Eg : Tomorrow I must begin a new life, with nothing but death behind me. I went on my way.
LANGUAGE ELEMENTS

1..Pick out the Noun Phrase in the subject position and Verb phrase in the sentence that follows.

A. The voice in the dark sounded impatient.
B. Monotonous, hopeless weeks passed by.
C. The first hard frosts came in the middle of December.
D. The doctor who took care of the child couldn't resist the temptation to listen to the angel's heart.
E. The line of pilgrims waiting their turn to enter reached beyond the horizon.

2.Complete the dialogues suitably:
Szpilman : ----------a----------?
Officer : No, I have no intention of doing anything to you.
Szpilman : Thank you sir.
Officer : Come with me, ---b-------?
Szpilman : Yes, sir. _____c_____ ?
Officer : Take the piano and play something. If somebody comes ----------d----------.
Szpilma : Would you mind ----------e--------
Officer : Sure. I will close the door.
3. Read the given dialogue and complete the sentences given below:
Officer: What do you do for a living?
Szpilman: I'm a pianist.
The officer asked ----------a----------
Szpilman replied --------b----------

4.Edit the given passage.
The doctor that (a) took care of the child can't (b) resist the temptation of (c) listen to the angel's heart. He found so many (d) whistling in a (e) heart and so many sounds in the kidneys.

5.Complete the given passage by choosing the suitable words given in brackets. (his, but, with, for, the)
They became alarmed, ----------(a) they thought he was going to die. And yet he not only survived his worst winter ----------(b) seemed improved ----------(c) the first sunny days. He remained motionless for several days in ----------(d) farthest corner of the courtyard. At the beginning of December, some large, stiff feathers began to grow on ----------(e)wings.

Answers

	NP	VP
A.	The voice in the dark	Sounded impatient.
B.	Monotonous, hopeless weeks	Passed by
C.	The first hard frosts	Came in the middle of December.
D.	The doctor who took care of the child	Couldn't resist the temptation to listen to the angel's heart.
E.	The line of pilgrims waiting their turn to enter	Reached beyond the horizon.

2. a. Do you have an intention of moving me from here?
b. will you? c. What shall I do for you?
d. you can hide somewhere. e. closing that door.
3. a. what he did for a living. b. that he was a pianist
4. a. who b. couldn't c. to d. so much e. the
5. a. for, b. but c. with d. the, e. his